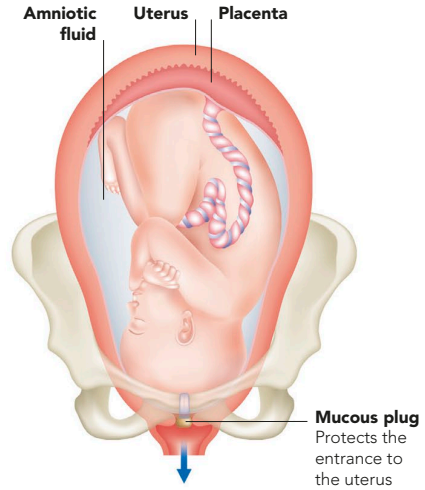


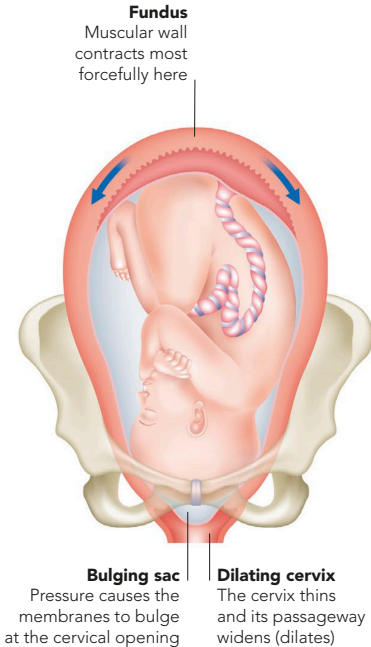
SIGNS OF EARLY LABOUR

Every woman's personal experience of childbirth is different, but generally there are three particular signs that labour is starting. First there is a "show", followed by contractions, and finally the waters break. Before labour begins (usually less than 3 days), the mucous plug in the cervix, which has been acting as a seal during pregnancy, is passed as a blood-stained or brownish discharge (the "show"). As the contractions of the uterus become stronger and more regular, the membranes that retain the amniotic fluid rupture (break), allowing the fluid (water) to leak out via the birth canal.



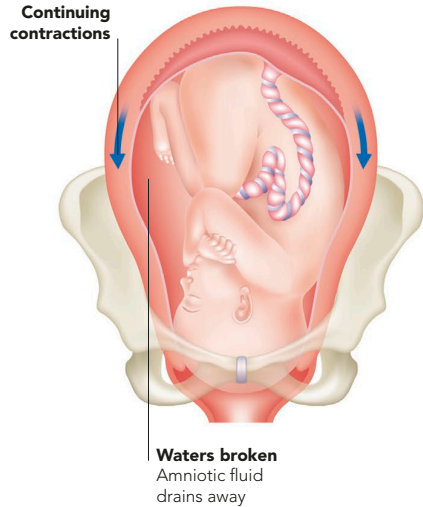
1 THE "SHOW"

For most of the time during a pregnancy, the mucous plug in the cervix prevents microbes from entering the uterus. As the cervix widens slightly, the plug loosens and falls out.



2 CONTRACTIONS

Coordinated muscular contractions are generated in the upper part of the uterus, called the fundus. This helps to gradually open, or dilate, the cervix.



3 WATER BREAKS

The amniotic sac (membrane) around the baby ruptures, or breaks, allowing colourless amniotic fluid to pass out through the birth canal.